

Winners and Establishable Cards

As soon as dummy comes down, declarer asks: how many tricks do I have? Where can I find more?



1 Winner

A card that, **played now**, wins the trick. Also called a **sure trick**.



2 winners
the ace and the king

2 Establishable card

A card that **will become** a winner after some work. Here the ace is missing: keep leading the suit until an opponent takes it.



0 winners
3 establishable

3 Establishing by force

Lead the suit one card at a time until the opponents take their higher honors. **It is the only technique that always works**: one hundred percent of the time.

4 Equal cards

Touching cards have the same power: in **AKQJ** the jack wins just like the ace, 4 winners. It works **across both hands** too: with AQ2 in dummy, South's king is a winner.

N ♠ AQ2
S ♠ K43

3 winners
as long as two honors never fall on the same trick

5 The long side rules

Never more tricks than cards in the long hand.

N ♠ J109

S ♠ AKQ

3 on each side
3 tricks

N ♥ 109

S ♥ AKQJ2

South has 5
5 tricks

N ♦ AKJ942

S ♦ Q103

North has 6
6 tricks

6 How many can you establish?

Cards in the long hand, minus the missing honors.

N ♣ KQ92

S ♣ J103

A missing
 $4 - 1 = 3$

N ♣ KQ954

S ♣ J103

A missing
 $5 - 1 = 4$

N ♥ Q9854

S ♥ J1032

A K missing
 $5 - 2 = 3$

N ♠ KJ9863

S ♠ Q102

A missing
 $6 - 1 = 5$

7 Declarer's plan, after the opening lead

1 · Count your winners

Suit by suit, across both hands.

2 · Find what to establish

Start with the suit that can give **the most tricks**.

3 · Establish, then cash

Don't rush to play your winners: you need them later.

Careful: sometimes, once the suit is established, you must regain the lead before you can cash it.

8 Let's try: South declares, West leads

NORTH · DUMMY

♠ AQ8 ♥ 76 ♦ K65 ♣ K10932

SOUTH · DECLARER

♠ K62 ♥ A982 ♦ A43 ♣ QJ6

West leads the Q♦

SUIT	WINNERS	ESTABLISHABLE	
♠ Spades	3	—	A K Q
♥ Hearts	1	—	A
♦ Diamonds	2	—	A K
♣ Clubs	0	4	5 - 1: the ace is missing
Total	6	+ 4	= 10 tricks

South wins the lead → plays **clubs** at once until the ace is gone → wins any return and cashes out